

Chapter 101-2 - Honesty

In the many days that followed, Ning Fuyi felt as if she were in a dream. If it weren't for having only one year, she would have even wanted to indulge forever on this mountain slope.

But she knew she couldn't. Finding Chu Qingqiu's soul was only part of what she should do. Chu Qingqiu would eventually return to Purple Cloud Peak¹, and she too must return to herself, facing the bloodshed and storms ahead.

She still had to completely destroy Penglai.

So one year's time was already extremely precious and hard-won.

Both of them carefully counted the days. After that night, she wished she could follow behind Su Mo every day - accompanying her up the mountain to gather herbs in the morning, helping her dig for medicine under her guidance. The silver earned was half again as much as before.

The Xiao family's debts were increasingly paid off. Ning Fuyi would also hunt some wild game to sell, exchanging it for rice and flour to improve their daily meals.

This was quite effective. Although their daily meals couldn't compare to even half of what they had at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate², they were flavorful and satisfying. Su Mo's small, thin body from childhood also became much more rounded and plump, her pointed little face becoming healthier and more beautiful.

Ning Fuyi also sought out doctors several times for her, all saying her body was healthy with no illness. Ning Fuyi couldn't help but feel hopeful - perhaps missing one soul wasn't serious, perhaps Su Mo could live a good full life.

After all, one year was really too short.

The days passed relentlessly. Soon the spring breeze was gone, scorching summer enveloped the fields, and the sun beat down on the earth daily, causing all the green grass to droop, wishing it could burrow into the dry, cracked earth.

Today Ning Fuyi hadn't accompanied Su Mo up the mountain, but had taken Jiuying³ to handle some matters. By the time they returned to the foot of the mountain, the sky had already darkened.

She landed with a body full of fatigue, straightened her clothing, and entered the small courtyard, smiling as she lifted a bag of sauced meat: "Su Mo, look what I brought back!"

Although Su Mo couldn't hear, she still habitually called out each day.

She had just knocked on the door when it creaked open. Lamplight spilled into the courtyard. She opened her arms with a beaming smile to embrace the woman who opened the door, placing her cheek against her neck and nuzzling.

Pretending to be extremely tired, she said: "Not seeing you for a day, did you miss me?"

If it were usual, Su Mo would have already opened her arms to return the embrace. But today was very different. She seemed to have returned to their first meeting, pushing Ning Fuyi away forcefully as if startled, so anxious that even the words she had learned couldn't be spoken clearly.

"Yiyi, don't, there are people..."

Hearing the words "there are people," Ning Fuyi finally regained her alertness. A scent different from Su Mo's entered her nostrils. She quickly raised her head, and after seeing the faces sitting around the table clearly, both sides of her cheeks immediately turned evenly red.

But she didn't release Su Mo. Instead, she took her hand as if making a declaration, interlocking their fingers.

"Long time no see. How did you also learn bad intentions, sneaking into my home without letting me discover it, specifically to watch my embarrassment?" Ning Fuyi curved up one corner of her mouth, closing the door behind her with her other hand and setting up a barrier.

During these days, she had never deliberately hidden anything from Su Mo, but to prevent her from being implicated in matters from her previous life, she still played the role of a mortal well. Su Mo also hadn't inquired too much, and the two had always maintained this tacit understanding, cherishing their limited time.

"You're wronging me. I was just passing through this area, couldn't find you, and was kept for a meal." Jiang Li⁴ smiled with deep dimples.

As she spoke, her gaze kept glancing at their clasped hands, looking as if her heart was in complete turmoil, yet she hesitated to speak.

The other three people kept their eyes on their noses and their noses on their hearts⁵, not daring to raise their heads.

"What's this? Haven't seen each other for months and you won't even give a greeting?" Seeing their awkwardness, Ning Fuyi became more at ease instead, pulling Su Mo to sit across from them and smiling: "Xique⁶."

Xique, dressed in plain white cloth, nervously raised her eyes. After seeing Ning Fuyi, she quickly lowered her head again: "Master."

"My servant." Ning Fuyi explained to Su Mo.

"Master." Hannya⁷ knew she hadn't been able to stop Jiang Li and didn't dare raise her head.

"Also my servant." Ning Fuyi introduced, and when her gaze swept over Hannya, it nearly made her feathers stand on end.

Su Mo was still somewhat shy around strangers, so she kept nestling close to Ning Fuyi, treating her like a lifeline and refusing to move away, causing the three people not to know where to look.

Xique and Hannya were manageable - at most they had heard of Chu Qingqiu's reputation in rumors. But Jiang Li was different. She had personally seen Chu Qingqiu's usual intimidating coldness. Now not only was she hit with a sense of disillusionment, but she also found time to worry about her own life.

If Chu Qingqiu remembered this later, she wouldn't kill to silence witnesses, would she? Watching someone's embarrassing moment and losing one's life over it would be quite worthless.

Thinking of this, she suddenly shivered, stood up gracefully, and straightened her shawl: "Since it's already late, we won't disturb you any longer. We'll come find you another day."

With that, she opened the door with lotus steps, but after stepping out, she immediately ran away without a trace. Xique and Hannya did the same, running faster than they could fly. Soon only the chirping of insects remained around them.

Ning Fuyi shook her head and turned to look at Su Mo, who was curiously leaning on the chair back to peer out the window, saying haltingly: "They, run, really fast."

"I'm sorry, I didn't know they would disturb you." Ning Fuyi reached out to tuck Su Mo's hair that had fallen over her forehead behind her ear, saying gently: "Don't be afraid, they're all good people."

Usually when she left, she would have Hannya secretly protect Su Mo. She hadn't expected Jiang Li to suddenly appear.

But it was good that Jiang Li was here. After all, half the year had already passed. Having a Medical Immortal around always provided more peace of mind.

Su Mo shook her head, her voice melodious as a musical instrument: "I'm, not afraid."

Su Mo could originally read lips, so learning to speak wasn't that difficult. Although she was still halting now, she could manage some daily communication.

Ning Fuyi opened her arms, and Su Mo naturally leaned into her embrace. Ning Fuyi then raised her hand to help her remove her short boots, allowing her to curl her legs up on the chair.

Su Mo really liked being held like this, curled up in a ball embracing the woman's waist. When held like this, she felt completely wrapped up securely, extremely at peace.

Seeing mud on the soles of her shoes, Ning Fuyi knew she had gone up the mountain alone again, but she didn't scold her. Instead, she slipped her hand under Su Mo's knees and gently lifted, letting her rest her legs on her own.

Su Mo had gained quite a bit of weight these days and felt more substantial to the touch, but she was still ultimately a slender girl.

Feeling the woman's hands pressing on her legs, Su Mo comfortably softened her body, resting her face on Ning Fuyi's shoulder.

"Yiyi. Want to, always, like this." She said softly.

Ning Fuyi paused for a moment, then nodded: "We will."

"You, like me, right?" Su Mo asked again.

She had been asking this question frequently lately, as if suffering from gain and loss. Ning Fuyi knew what she was thinking, so she patiently answered clearly: "Mm. Of course."

Having received her answer, Su Mo felt relieved, her eyes slowly closing as drowsiness enveloped her.

"Su Mo, I have to leave again tomorrow. This time I'm afraid it will be two or three days." Although Ning Fuyi really couldn't bear it, she still spoke up.

Su Mo, who was almost asleep, suddenly opened her eyes, the clarity returning to her clear gaze.

She was stunned for a moment, hummed in acknowledgment, and didn't say much more: "Okay, I'll, wait, for Yiyi."

These past few months, Ning Fuyi had postponed demon clan matters whenever possible, leaving everything to Jiuying and Shang Chou⁸ to handle. But this current matter concerned Penglai and was extremely important - she had to go personally.

"I'm sorry for not keeping my promise to accompany you." Ning Fuyi sighed.

"I'm, not a, child. Don't need you, to accompany me, every day." Su Mo smiled. She stared into Ning Fuyi's phoenix eyes for a while, then suddenly closed her eyes and leaned close, pointing to her moist, lustrous red lips.

"Kiss me." This phrase came out without stuttering.

Footnotes:

1. **Purple Cloud Peak (紫霞峰)** - Chu Qingqiu's residence and the seat of her power as a Divine Venerable.
2. **Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate (云际山门)** - The sect that Ning Fuyi was previously associated with, representing the cultivation world she left behind.
3. **Jiuying (九婴)** - Ning Fuyi's contracted demon beast companion, a nine-headed creature of great power.
4. **Jiang Li (江离)** - A Medical Immortal who has been helping treat Ning Fuyi's condition and is aware of her true identity.
5. **Eyes on noses, noses on hearts (眼观鼻鼻观心)** - A Chinese idiom meaning to mind one's own business and avoid looking at inappropriate things.
6. **Xique (喜鹊)** - Literally "magpie," one of Ning Fuyi's demon servants who has taken human form.
7. **Hannya (寒鸦)** - Literally "cold crow," another of Ning Fuyi's demon servants, originally a crow spirit.
8. **Shang Chou (商仇)** - Another member of Ning Fuyi's demon faction, helping to manage affairs in her absence.